

More British and American spellings

SPELLING DIFFERENCES BETWEEN BRITISH AND AMERICAN ENGLISH CAN SOMETIMES AFFECT A WORD'S PRONUNCIATION.

Small differences between British and American spellings do not usually change the meaning of a word. However, British English may use two words to indicate two meanings, whereas American English uses the same word for both meanings.

SEE ALSO

◀ 142–143 Prefixes and suffixes

◀ 146–147 Words ending in -e or -y

◀ 154–155 Single and double consonant words

◀ 160–161 Silent letters

◀ 162–163 Compound words

Different sounds or words

A minor change in the spelling of a word can affect its sound, even if the meaning is the same. Occasionally, British and American English use different words to mean the same thing.

British English

aeroplane

aluminium

disorientated

pavement

sledge

American English

airplane

aluminum

disoriented

sidewalk

sleigh or sled

Different meanings

Sometimes, British English uses two words that sound the same but with different spellings to indicate different meanings. American English uses the same word for both meanings.

The *Oxford English Dictionary* is widely thought to be the **authority** on the English language and includes both **British** and **American** spellings.

In British English, this refers to the edge of a sidewalk.

kerb

In British English, this is a level within a building.

storey

In British English, this means to request information.

enquire

In British English, this refers to a unit of length.

metre

In British English, this is the rubber part of a wheel.

tyre

curb

In British English, this means to restrain. In American English, *curb* is used for both meanings.

story

In British English, this refers to a tale or work of fiction. In American English, *story* is used for both meanings.

inquire

In British English, this means to conduct an investigation. In American English, *inquire* is used for both meanings.

meter

In British English, this refers to a device used for measuring. In American English, *meter* is used for both meanings.

tire

In British English, this refers to becoming weary. In American English, *tire* is used for both meanings.

or